Bank's housekeeping department arranged for this office to be used by Rajan during the understudy period. He shuttled between Delhi and Mumbai during the month, but I took care to keep him in the loop on all important developments, including managing the exchange rate which dominated my agenda during that period.

What Would You Have Done Differently?

'What would you have done differently?' is a question that has crossed my mind several times since stepping down. This is also one of the pointed questions that Mythili Bhusnurmath of ETV hurled at me in the only formal, exclusive TV interview that I had done since leaving the Reserve Bank. At one level, this is an incomplete question. The full question, in my view, should be: 'What would you have done differently if you knew what you now know?' With the benefit of hindsight, one may, in fact, do many things differently. On the other hand, if the question were 'What would you have done differently if you were operating within the universe of knowledge available at that time?', the answer may be, 'Not very much.'

The writing of this book involved a lot of introspection into my time at the Reserve Bank to identify in particular what I got right and what I didn't get right. Without getting into the logical fallacy outlined above, I tried to indicate, wherever the context demanded, what I could have done better even with the knowledge available in real time and what I would have done differently with the benefit of hindsight. In one sentence, if indeed I had a second chance, I would pay much greater attention to communicating more effectively.

I still have a fairly vivid recall of one of the topics that came up for discussion when I appeared before the civil services interview board way back in 1972. I wrote in my application that I was on the IIT debating team. 'What was the latest topic you debated on?' a member asked me. That happened to be: 'Man is condemned to be free', a statement from the existentialist philosophy of Jean Paul Sartre. The interview board members